

On: what their public marketing signals are actually saying

A short, evidence-based read of what's publicly visible — not internal data I don't have access to.

How this was built: every point below is checkable by anyone, using On's own published returns and shipping pages, and what's directly visible in general product search. Nothing here claims insight into revenue, sell-through, or internal reporting.

1. Returns are gated to direct purchases only

- On's own returns page is explicit: "If you didn't buy your product directly from On you won't be able to return or exchange it on our website."
- No exceptions offered, no path back for a customer who bought through a retailer — they're sent away at the very first step.
- The policy applies regardless of the reason for return, so even a genuine sizing or defect issue routes back through whichever retailer made the sale, not On directly.

3. The lockout is also a missed retention moment

- A returns flow is one of the few guaranteed moments a reseller's customer interacts directly with On's own site.
- Right now that moment ends in a dead end, rather than an account signup, a loyalty offer, or anything that turns a one-off reseller buyer into a direct relationship.
- Even a simple size or fit record captured at that moment would give On a first-party data point on a customer it otherwise knows nothing about.

2. Most visible purchase touchpoints aren't on.com

- General product search for On's shoes returns third-party retailers — department stores, resellers, regional sports retailers — well ahead of on.com itself in visible results.
- That's consistent with a genuinely wholesale-heavy distribution model, which makes the direct-purchase-only returns policy a mainstream experience, not an edge case.
- It also means most of the actual buying decision — price comparison, sizing questions, reviews — happens on someone else's site, using someone else's data, not On's own.

4. Shipping terms aren't on one global page

- On's own shipping information is split by country page rather than stated once — their own copy points users to "our international shipping" as a separate lookup.
- For a brand selling in dozens of markets that's a reasonable structure, but it means no single page answers "what will this cost me" without knowing to check the right regional version first.

What this pattern usually means: a wholesale-heavy growth strategy is a genuinely good way to scale distribution fast, and On has clearly done that well. The trade-off is that the brand's own site becomes a smaller share of the real customer relationship than the marketing suggests — and right now, the one moment that trade-off shows up (a returns request) is treated as an exit, not an opportunity.

What I'd check first, in order

- 1 Turn the reseller-return dead end into a signup moment.** Even a simple "here's how to return it, and here's 10% off your next direct order" converts a wasted visit into a first-party relationship.

- 2 Add one global shipping-cost summary page.** Country-specific detail can stay, but a single page answering the basic question saves a real share of visitors a redundant lookup.

- 3 Measure what share of traffic is actually reseller-return traffic.** If it's meaningful volume, the fix in step one has a direct, calculable payback.



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